harbours of Asia and Europe.’

It was towards this end, he continued, that the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company was being formed with a capital of Rs 10 lakh. It was up to patriotic Indians, rich and poor, to buy the 40,000 shares at Rs 25 each to fund the company. The prospectus then provided details of the cost of steamers and launches, the anticipated revenue in Tuticorin and Colombo and a break-up of various expenses. According to his calculations, it would require Rs 5 lakh to buy two steamers of between 1250 and 1500 net tons. While a steam launch would cost Rs 50,000, a further capital outlay of Rs 1 lakh would be required. Other expenses such as wages for the crew, coal, anchorage and other duties, stevedore expenses, water for boilers, advertisement and repairs would work out to Rs 4,85,000 annually. VOC’s estimates of annual passenger traffic and cargo, as well as the revenue, were as follows: 2,88,000 third-class (Rs 2-8-0 per ticket), 7,200 second-class (at Rs 7-8-0 per ticket) and 3,600 first-class (Rs 15-0-0 per ticket) passengers were expected to travel annually. Similarly, 27,000 cattle and 1,44,000 goats and sheep were the estimated exports from Tuticorin. While 2,16,000 sacks would be shipped from Tuticorin, 72,000 sacks would be loaded from Colombo. The estimated excess of revenue over expenses would yield an annual profit of Rs 10,00,000! It was a grand scheme indeed.

Response to the Appeal

The reception from ardent nationalists was on expected lines. The poet Subramania Bharati, die-hard romanticist and champion of the Tilak camp, was ecstatic. While industry and handicraft were foundational for economic development, Bharati argued, they would fall flat if the nation did not possess the transport infrastructure to distribute the goods produced. As long as the transport network was in alien hands, Swadeshi industry could hardly survive, let alone prosper. While building a railroad network would have to await political change, running shipping companies was well within Indian means, or so Bharati believed. He called for the launch of more Swadeshi lines to exploit the sea route between Rangoon and Karachi, and